

Fifth Edition

Modern South Asia

History, Culture, Political Economy

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal



MODERN SOUTH ASIA

The fifth edition of *Modern South Asia* draws on the newest historical research and scholarship in the field to interpret and debate key developments in modern South Asian history and historical writing, covering the diverse spectrum of the subcontinent's social, economic and political past.

Jointly authored by two leading Indian and Pakistani historians, this definitive study offers a rare depth of historical understanding of the politics, cultures and economies that have shaped the lives of more than a fifth of humanity. This new edition on the 75th anniversary of independence and partition brings the narrative up to the present day, discussing recent events and addressing new themes such as the capture of state power in India by the forces of religious majoritarianism, economic development in the context of the 'rise' of Asia and strategic shifts occasioned by the US withdrawal from Afghanistan and China's increasing role in the region.

Providing fresh insights into the structure and ideology of the British raj, the meaning of subaltern resistance, the refashioning of social relations along lines of caste, class, religion and gender, the different strands of anti-colonial nationalism and the dynamics of decolonization, this is an essential resource for all students of the modern history of South Asia in an Indian Ocean and global context.

Sugata Bose is Gardiner Professor of Oceanic History and Affairs at Harvard University, USA. His books include *A Hundred Horizons: The Indian Ocean in the Age of Global Empire* (2006) and *His Majesty's Opponent: Subhas Chandra Bose and India's Struggle against Empire* (2011).

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Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal

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Fifth edition published 2023

by Routledge

4 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon, OX14 4RN

and by Routledge

605 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10158

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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First edition published by Routledge in 1998

Fourth edition published by Routledge in 2017

British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data

A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Names: Bose, Sugata, 1956- author. | Jalal, Ayesha, author.

Title: Modern South Asia : history, culture, political economy / Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal.

Description: Fifth edition. | Abingdon, Oxon ; New York, NY :

Routledge, 2023. | Includes bibliographical references and index.

Identifiers: LCCN 2022017654 (print) | LCCN 2022017655 (ebook) |

ISBN 9781032124230 (hbk) | ISBN 9781032124186 (pbk) | ISBN

9781003224488 (ebk)

Subjects: LCSH: South Asia--History.

Classification: LCC DS340 .B66 2023 (print) | LCC DS340 (ebook) |

DDC 954--dc23/eng/20220429

LC record available at <https://lcn.loc.gov/2022017654>

LC ebook record available at <https://lcn.loc.gov/2022017655>

ISBN: 978-1-032-12423-0 (hbk)

ISBN: 978-1-032-12418-6 (pbk)

ISBN: 978-1-003-22448-8 (ebk)

DOI: 10.4324/9781003224488

Typeset in Sabon

by MPS Limited, Dehradun

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PREFACE TO THE FIFTH EDITION OF *MODERN SOUTH ASIA*: *HISTORY, CULTURE,* *POLITICAL ECONOMY*

Modern South Asia first appeared on the occasion of the 50th anniversary of South Asian independence and partition in 1997–98. A second edition was published in 2004, a third in 2011, and a fourth in 2017. This revised and expanded fifth edition is being published on the occasion of the 75th anniversary of the subcontinent's independence and partition in 2022.

Our narrative has been brought up to date to the present with a new chapter on South Asia in the twenty-first century. The new chapter addresses the challenges to democracy in South Asia with the rise of religious majoritarianism and authoritarianism. We consider the extent to which contemporary crises are rooted in states of exception written into colonial and post-colonial legal regimes. This has entailed a fuller treatment of constitution-making processes discussed in earlier chapters.

Second, we have included new scholarship that has emerged from the research of a younger generation of historians on the early modern and modern periods of South Asian history.

The occasion of the 75th anniversary has enabled us to offer fresh insights into the history of partition, its enduring legacy, and ways of transcending its borders in historical scholarship.

Modern South Asia has always presented to students and the general reader the cutting-edge historical research on the subcontinent. Successive editions have incorporated fresh contributions to the formation of regional identities in South Asia, the connections of the subcontinent to a larger Indian Ocean inter-regional arena, and methodological innovations in the study of the history of political and economic ideas emanating from South Asia. We hope the fifth edition will be considered worthy of the 75th anniversary observance of South Asian independence.

We wish to record our deepest gratitude to our undergraduate and graduate students at Tufts University and Harvard University. Their responses to our lectures have helped us immeasurably to improve our text. Several of our PhD students have by now become illustrious colleagues in the historical profession. The five editions of *Modern South Asia* provide

PREFACE TO THE FIFTH EDITION

a remarkable record of the advances in modern South Asian history and historiography over a quarter of a century.

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal
February 2, 2022

PREFACE TO THE FOURTH EDITION

Modern South Asia first appeared on the occasion of the fiftieth anniversary of South Asian independence and partition in 1997–1998. A second edition was published in 2004 and a third in 2011. This revised and expanded fourth edition is being published on the seventieth anniversary of the subcontinent's independence in 2017.

This edition takes account of the new developments in South Asian history and historiography in the last twenty years. The post-colonial era gets more detailed coverage. There have been significant political and economic developments since our last revision of 2010 that are placed in the context of longer-term trajectories discussed in earlier chapters. Among the themes that have received attention are the capture of state power in India by the forces of religious majoritarianism and their tussle with regional political currents; economic development in India in the larger context of the 'rise' of Asia and in comparison with China; and strategic shifts in India and Pakistan occasioned by the US withdrawal from Afghanistan.

Modern South Asia has always presented to students and the general reader the cutting-edge historical research on the subcontinent. New books have appeared on the ancient, medieval and early modern periods that have led us to refine the interpretations offered in the first three chapters. The last six years have witnessed the publication of outstanding new research monographs on modern history by younger scholars, some of whom have been our own graduate students. These works have consolidated the trend we noted in the third edition of placing South Asia in larger inter-regional and global contexts. The fourth edition, therefore, highlights the best of comparative and connective historical scholarship in South Asia.

This 70th anniversary edition is dedicated to our mothers – Krishna Bose and Zakia Jalal – who have lived through the era of independence and partition to the contemporary moment with grace and dignity.

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal
February 2017

PREFACE TO THE THIRD EDITION

The inexorable march of history necessitates periodic revisions and new editions of general works of historical scholarship. The changes that need to be taken account of are primarily of two kinds. First, significant recent events need to be assessed in the context of longer-term structures and processes. Second, new knowledge generated by cutting-edge research deserves to find a place in any major work of synthesis and interpretation.

Modern South Asia was first written on the occasion of the fiftieth anniversary of South Asian independence and partition in 1997 and a second, revised edition appeared in 2004. During the six years that have now intervened crucial developments have taken place both in terms of historically significant events and innovative historical scholarship. We had argued in the first edition that the idea of changeless tradition in South Asia was always a myth. While certain structures of material life may be slow moving over time, nothing is a simple 'given' from the past. Traditions with deep roots in the past are always in the process of being reinterpreted. If we consider what might be called a medium-term conjuncture from the late eighteenth century to the early twentieth, South Asia can be seen to be going through a world-historical transformation. In many ways, the region is recovering the global position it had lost in economic, political and cultural terms at the onset of British colonial rule. So far as the history of events is concerned, South Asia has witnessed more than its due share of dramatic assassinations and insurgencies as well as changes of regimes.

The trend that we had noticed in the second edition of new historical scholarship on the formation of regional and religious identities gathered further momentum in the last few years with the publication of insightful first books by younger scholars, some but by no means all being our own former graduate students. The theme of the intricate relationship between religion and politics has engaged our own scholarly interest, as is evident from Ayesha Jalal's *Partisans of Allah: Jihad in South Asia* published in 2008. South Asian history has been placed creatively in the wider context of the inter-regional arena on the Indian Ocean as well as connections of a global scope. Our involvement in the writing of new connective histories is

PREFACE TO THE THIRD EDITION

exemplified in Sugata Bose's *A Hundred Horizons: the Indian Ocean in the Age of Global Empire* that came out in 2006. South Asian historiography has been enriched of late by a renewed interest in the history of economic and political ideas in a transnational frame. Our own work in this field and that of our many colleagues and students find reflection in this revised third edition of *Modern South Asia*.

Our leaves from Harvard and Tufts in the spring semester of 2010 enabled us to complete this work of revision, expansion and refinement of our text. We have put together the third edition in Calcutta and Lahore and we wish to thank our mothers Krishna Bose and Zakia Jalal for their support. We hope the new edition will continue to be the book of choice of teachers and students of modern South Asian history as well as interested non-specialists in the subject.

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal
Summer 2010, in Calcutta and Lahore

PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

The first edition of *Modern South Asia* had been published some six years ago on the occasion of the fiftieth anniversary of the subcontinent's independence and partition. We have been gratified by the enthusiastic response it has received from teachers, students and non-specialist readers with an intelligent interest in South Asia.

There are primarily three reasons for publishing a second, revised edition at this stage. First, the strength of *Modern South Asia* lies in its use of the newest and the most sophisticated historical research and scholarship in the field. In the past six years there has been some excellent new work, particularly on the formation of religious, regional and national identities in South Asia, which is reflected in the new edition. South Asian historiography in this area is moving beyond the dichotomy between statist, 'secular' histories and communitarian, 'subaltern' histories towards a subtler understanding of the place of religion in the public sphere. The second edition of *Modern South Asia* aspires to convey to a general readership the current and cutting-edge state-of-the-art. We are grateful to our former PhD students, now colleagues in the academy, for spurring us to do so. Second, *Modern South Asia* in its first edition had narrated the subcontinent's history up to 1997. Key developments since that date – not least the 1998 nuclear tests, the rise of the BJP to power in India, yet another military regime in Pakistan and new twists and turns in India–Pakistan relations – all suggested that the story needed to be brought up to date in purely chronological terms. Third, we have now had occasion to rethink some of the key issues discussed in the first edition and have received sufficient feedback from our colleagues and students to engage in a chapter by chapter revision. For example, we have rewritten the introduction and shifted the more difficult discussion of historiography to the beginning of the bibliography. In the chapter on the eighteenth century or India between empires we may have leaned a little too far towards the thesis about decentralization rather than decline. We seek to restore the balance somewhat in the second edition on the relationship between region and religion. The chapters on the colonial state have more to say on the raj without losing the general focus on Indian society. We have a few new

PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

insights into Gandhi's thought and practice, at variance with existing interpretations, which we bring into play in the chapter on the 1920s. We have added material on Muslim society and politics throughout, including the discussion of partition, and updated chapters 18, 19 and 20. A chronology of key events is supplied at the end of the book.

We wish to record our gratitude to our mothers, Krishna Bose and Zakia Jalal, for their support.

We hope that the second edition, like its predecessor, will help generate discussion and debate about South Asian history. *Modern South Asia* combines a narrative with synthesis and interpretation. We trust that in an improved second edition it will continue to be the book of choice for teachers, students and non-specialist readers searching for the one authoritative and enjoyable book on South Asian history.

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal
April 2003

PREFACE TO THE FIRST EDITION

Times of commemoration can occasion fresh ways of rethinking the past. And 1997 seemed as good a moment as any other to bring together the myriad threads of modern South Asian history, pause and reconsider, while taking account of the more important findings of recent historical research. The shifting parameters of scholarly debate on South Asian historiography with the unfolding of the process of decolonization of the mind need to be placed before a broader audience. In deciding to put together a general history of the South Asian subcontinent, the audience we had foremost in our minds was the younger generation of South Asians and students interested in South Asia. That is why we have chosen to dedicate this book to our nieces and nephews and through their hands to the next generation. We hope of course that our book will engage interested non-specialists of whatever generation curious about South Asian history.

Our deepest debt in writing this book is to our students at Columbia University and Tufts University who heard earlier versions of our arguments in the form of lectures. Their queries as well as occasional incomprehension has greatly helped to sharpen and clarify our interpretation of complex historical processes and events. Interactions with our graduate students, Ritu Birla, Semanti Ghosh, Farina Mir, Mridu Rai, Shabnum Tejani and Chitrlekha Zutshi, have militated against over-simplification. Farina Mir and Shabnum Tejani at Columbia and Semanti Ghosh and Chitrlekha Zutshi at Tufts have served as our teaching assistants and contributed to the finer points of our text.

We are grateful to a number of our colleagues for reading the manuscript in whole or in part and making invaluable comments. Kumkum Roy cast an eye over our chapter on ancient India while Muzaffar Alam and Mridu Rai scrutinised the three chapters dealing with the period from c. 700 to c. 1800. Christopher Bayly did a critical reading of the entire manuscript and made a number of apt suggestions. David Washbrook also read the manuscript through and toasted its success even before it was published. We benefitted from the comments on our proposal by the four readers of Routledge. The two anonymous readers for Oxford University Press made

PREFACE TO THE FIRST EDITION

perhaps the most astute comments on the pages of an earlier version of the manuscript. We would not have got our manuscript ready if not for the prodding encouragement of Rukun Advani of OUP-Delhi who has published some of the best research on modern South Asian history in the last two decades. The enthusiasm of Heather McCallum at Routledge was a source of confidence while Bela Malik at OUP-Delhi competently attended to the editorial task of getting the manuscript ready for the printers.

Once more we have to thank our families for their continued and warming support of our scholarly endeavours. We would like to thank each other for choosing the path of negotiation rather than war when it came to addressing disputes and disagreements in the course of writing this book. It is our hope that this work will encourage more dialogues across the great divide of 1947. Our contribution to the fiftieth anniversary of independence and partition will have been made if it enables the opening of an intellectual and cultural corridor stretching from Lahore to Calcutta.

Sugata Bose and Ayesha Jalal

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The authors and publishers would like to thank the following for granting permission to use copyright material in the volume:

Nehru Memorial Museum and Library (Figures 11.1 and 17.4)

Netaji Research Bureau (Figures 15.1, 16.1, 16.2, 17.2, 17.3 and 17.6)

Ananda Bazaar Patrika (Figures 19.1 and 20.1)

Information Division, Embassy of Pakistan, Washington, DC (Figure 17.5)

Ayesha Jalal, *The Sole Spokesman* (Cambridge University Press, 1985)
(Maps 15.1 and 17.1)

Ayesha Jalal, *Democracy and Authoritarianism in South Asia* (Cambridge University Press, 1995) (Map 20.1)

C.A. Bayly, *The Raj* (National Gallery Publications, 1990) (Maps 5.1 and 9.1)

The Trustees of Victoria Memorial Hall, Kolkata, India (Figure 12.2)

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Faiz Ahmed Faiz poem ‘Freedom’s Dawn’ (August 1947) in Poems by Faiz, translated by V. G. Kiernan, India: Oxford University Press, 2000

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SOUTH ASIAN HISTORY

An introduction

The very idea of India, and not just its wealth and wisdom, has been the site of fierce historical contestation. G.W.F. Hegel, the famous German philosopher, gave a not untypical nineteenth-century description of India as an object of desire:

From the most ancient times downwards, all nations have directed their wishes and longings to gaining access to the treasures of this land of marvels, the most costly which the Earth presents; treasures of Nature – pearls, diamonds, perfumes, rose-essences, elephants, lions, etc. – as also treasures of wisdom. The way by which these treasures have passed to the West, has at all times been a matter of World-historical importance, bound up with the fate of nations.

He added approvingly, ‘the English, or rather the East-India Company are the lords of the land; for it is the necessary fate of Asiatic Empires to be subjected to Europeans ...’. In the early twentieth century Gandhi lamented in his tract *Hind Swaraj*:

the English have not taken India; we have given it to them. They are not in India because of their strength but because we keep them ... Recall the Company Bahadur. Who made it Bahadur ... it is truer to say that we gave India to the English than that India was lost.

The battle to win India back was waged not only on the political plane but also in the realm of ideas. A turn-of-the-century Indian nationalist Bipin Chandra Pal, in his book *The Soul of India*, delved back into ancient history in attempting to question the Western definition of India: ‘... while the stranger called her India, or the land of the Indus, thereby emphasizing only her strange physical features, her own children, from of old, have known and loved her by another name ... that name is Bharatavarsha’. This name deriving from the ancient king of kings Bharata, Pal claimed, was ‘not a physical name like India or the Transvaal, nor even a tribal and ethnic name

like England or Aryavarta, but a distinct and unmistakable historic name like Rome.' India may have been a name given by foreigners, but its emotive appeal came to be internalized by many inhabitants of this land. The ancient Persians and Arabs referred to the land beyond the river Sindhu or Indus as Al-Hind or Hindustan and the people inhabiting that land as Hindu. The words India and Indian were simply Greek, Roman and finally, English versions of the old Persian terminology. It was only gradually that the term Hindu came to be associated with the followers of a particular religious faith as a matter of convenience since the 'Hindus' did not deploy a single term to define their religion. The leading twentieth-century Muslim poet writing in Urdu had no difficulty celebrating Hindustan as his own. Muhammad Iqbal in his 'Tarana-i-Hindi' (The Anthem of Hind) of 1904 extolled the virtues of his homeland:

*Sarey jahan sey achhaa, ye Hindustan hamara
Hum bulbulen hain iske, ye gulistan hamara*

(Better than the whole world, is our Hindustan
We are its singing birds, it is our garden of delights)

Iqbal later became one of the foremost proponents of a homeland for India's Muslims. On the eve of partition in 1947, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, widely acknowledged as the founder of this homeland, wrote indignantly about 'the wholly unwarranted assumption that Pakistan would be an area seceding from the Indian state', arguing that there could be no union of India without the Muslim-majority areas of the subcontinent. In the seventy-five years since independence and partition the political and ideological contests among its own people for proprietorship over the soul of the subcontinent have, if anything, greatly intensified.

It is not unusual for peoples burdened by history in their own contexts to be transformed into peoples without history in others. Given the tendency towards the 'essentializing' of India by Western orientalist over the past two centuries, it is no surprise that in the Western popular consciousness the Indian subcontinent tended to evoke two contrary images until the late twentieth century. On the one hand, it was lauded as an ancient land of mystery and romance, extraordinary wealth and profound spirituality. On the other, it was denounced for its irrationality and inhumanity and derided for its destitution and squalor. Even after the *maharaja* of old had been reduced to a caricature in the advertisement of India's loss-making and now privatized national airline, television audiences in both Britain and the United States were entranced since the 1980s by the nostalgia of India's final fling with the British raj. Yet one had only to switch from the channel showing the soap opera to the news to find the coveted jewel in the crown portrayed as a veritable crucible of calamity,

confusion and chaos. Stark poverty replaced the vision of India's grandeur, religious strife rudely disturbed the calm of other-worldly meditation, and fierce violence unleashed by both man and nature seemed to make a mockery of the peaceful messages of a Buddha or a Gandhi. Both images, whether optimistically fanciful or pejoratively stereotypical, stemmed from an inability to understand or comprehend, far less explain, the enormous complexities of South Asia.

The dawn of the twenty-first century witnessed the rise of a new set of contradictory images. Dynamic economic growth, the emergence of a number of high-profile billionaire entrepreneurs and a booming consumer culture in urban areas, especially but not only in India, seemed to portend 'a rise' alongside China after two centuries of poverty and relative economic decline. By contrast, a Maoist insurgency spreading ominously across India's tribal heartland, coupled with stories of sporadic farmers' agitations and suicides, suggested that the problem of inequities and gross disparities had been further compounded in the contemporary phase of globalization. Meanwhile, the turbulence in Pakistan's tribal frontier acquired menacing proportions in the two decades following the 11 September 2001 terrorist attacks in the USA and the American military retaliation in Afghanistan. The violence spilled into the metropolitan cities, often in the form of ghastly suicide bombings. The chaotic US withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021 enhanced the risks and uncertainties facing the region. The stage of the United Nations continues to witness Indian and Pakistani leaders trading charges of human rights violations and cross-border terrorism. Caught as always in the vortex of global opportunities and conflicts, South Asia finds itself seven and a half decades after independence at one of the more significant milestones in its history.

The subcontinent defies piecemeal approaches much the same way as the proverbial elephant confounded the blind men in the famous story by the Muslim Sufi poet, Jalaluddin Rumi. When made to touch the different parts of the elephant's anatomy, each of the blind men described it according to the part of the body his hands had touched. So to one blind man the elephant appeared like a throne, to others like a fan, a water pipe and even a pillar. No one could imagine what the whole animal looked like. This book promises to present a view of India and South Asia with the blindfolds off. Recourse to history is indispensable in order to broaden perspective and sharpen focus. A single volume on the complex history of the subcontinent can only offer a glimpse of its richness and nuance, but with a good angle of vision it could be a penetrating and insightful glimpse.

What then is this Indian subcontinent – or South Asia, as it has come to be known in more recent and neutral parlance – whose history will be interpreted in this book? Both South Asia and India are in origin geographical expressions. South Asia is a more recent construction – only seven and a half decades old – which today encompasses eight very diverse sovereign

states of very different sizes: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Afghanistan, Bhutan and the Maldives. Some would also include Myanmar, which as Burma was a province of British India until 1935. The term India, as we have seen, is of much older origin. What South Asia lacks in historical depth, it makes up for in political neutrality. The terms South Asia and India refer in the first instance to a vast geographical space stretching from the Himalayan mountain ranges in the north to the Indian Ocean in the south and from the valley of the Indus in the west to the plains of the Brahmaputra in the east. This huge geographical expanse has become home to a teeming population of well over a billion people, who account for over a fifth or, to be more precise, 23 per cent of humanity. The subcontinent carries the weight not only of its people but also of their ancient history stretching back at least five millennia, and a modern history encompassing the experience of British colonialism compressed in tumultuous developments within the past couple of centuries.

It is a commonplace in any introduction to South Asian history to expound on the cliché about the region's unity in diversity. It may be more appropriate to characterize South Asia and its peoples as presenting a picture of diversity in unity, indeed of immense diversity within a very broad contour of unity. The geographical boundaries drawn by the highest mountain ranges in the world and encircling seas and oceans set the whole of the subcontinent apart from the rest of the world. Yet within these boundaries there is great diversity in natural attributes – imposing hills and mountains, lush green river plains, arid deserts and brown plateaus. Peoples inhabiting such a clearly defined, yet diverse, region have evolved a shared cultural ambience, but at the same time are deeply attached to distinctive cultural beliefs and practices. Over the millennia the peoples of the subcontinent have engaged in many cultural exchanges with the outside world and worked out creative accommodations of cultural difference within.

The peoples of South Asia speak at least twenty major languages, and if one includes the more important dialects, the count rises to over two hundred. A panoply of very diverse languages and language families, South Asia has made enormous contributions to world literature from ancient to modern times. It has achieved major accomplishments in the arts and maintains distinguished musical traditions. Adherents to every major world religion are to be found in the subcontinent. It is the source of two of the world's great religions and the home to more devotees of a third than either the Middle East or Southeast Asia. Hinduism, with its ancient roots, modern transformations and multiple interpretations, plays a vital part in the culture and politics of the subcontinent. Hindus form the majority of India's population, but are distinguished along lines of language and caste. While the formal adherents to Buddhism may have dwindled in the land of its birth, it continues to flourish in Sri Lanka and the Himalayas as well as in East and Southeast Asia. Some of the greatest cultural and political

achievements of Islam have taken place in the subcontinent, where more than half a billion of the world's 1.9 billion Muslims live today. Each of the three most populous countries in South Asia – India, Bangladesh and Pakistan – has over 200 million Muslims, next only to Indonesia as the largest Muslim countries in the world. South Asia also has significant Jain, Zoroastrian, Christian and Sikh minorities.

South Asia today is strategically a vital part of the world that has large implications for the international order at the beginning of the new millennium. With the testing of nuclear devices by India and Pakistan in 1998, the continuing conflict in Kashmir, and the long drawn US war in Afghanistan and its aftermath fanning into Pakistan's northwestern tribal areas, the subcontinent attracted more than the usual dose of media attention. The location of one of the most intractable international problems of the past seventy-five years that could still trigger a catastrophic war, South Asia demands a depth of historical understanding. Since the early 1990s South Asia, especially India, has undergone crucial shifts in economic policy, making it important to assess the region's linkages to the global economy, along with an examination of its persistent problems of poverty and inequality. Genuine prospects of peace, democracy and cooperative development vie with disputes such as Kashmir to place South Asia at a decisive crossroads in its history. Flourishing electoral democracy coexists in the region with deep strains of authoritarianism, often within the same country. In spite of very strong and persistent, often localized, traditions, the notion of changeless 'tradition' in South Asia was always a myth, but perhaps never more so than at the present moment, as South Asians negotiate their place in an arena of global interconnections in the throes of rapid change. How do we begin to address the long and complex history of the peoples of this subcontinent?

Over the millennia South Asia developed rich and complex layers of culture, which during recent centuries had a dramatic historical encounter with the West. This is a book on modern history, concentrating on the problem of change in society, economy and politics from *c.* 1700 to the present in subcontinental South Asia – mainly but not exclusively present-day India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Three background chapters unravelling the more important features of India's pre-colonial history set the stage for the detailed treatment of British colonialism in India and its aftermath. A focus on the colonial period does not entail missing out on South Asia's pre-colonial heritage, since much of India's 'tradition' was recast, if not re-invented, during the colonial era, a process analysed in some detail in this book. But in order to grasp the issue of continuity and change under colonialism the book shifts the emphasis away from the concerns and imperatives of the imperial masters. Colonial initiatives in and of themselves cannot encapsulate the complex and at times largely autonomous and certainly contested dynamics that moulded relationships in Indian society,

economy and polity. Colonialism as an agency of historical change is placed in its appropriate social context and studied in its interplay with the culture and politics of anti-colonial resistance.

The enormous difficulty in fashioning a balanced yet insightful approach to the study of modern South Asia is reflected in the yawning gap between a few general histories and the large number of research monographs and scholarly articles published over the last four decades. Most of the general works that do exist are no more than one-dimensional sketches of the metaphorical Indian elephant, while more rigorous and sophisticated research has dissected discrete parts of its complex anatomy. The challenge before us is to find a good perspective for a multi-dimensional, high-definition overview of modern South Asian history in the pages of a single book.

South Asian historiography has achieved a remarkable level of depth and sophistication in recent decades. This book is a work of synthesis and interpretation covering the entire spectrum of modern South Asian history – cultural, economic, political and social – that seeks to take full account of the striking new developments in the field. A number of major themes have emerged in recent historical research. These need to be placed within a general context. Among these have been the role of intermediate social groups in the construction of the British raj and that of ‘subaltern’ social groups in anti-colonial resistance; the part played by the colonial state in the re-invention of ‘communal’ and caste categories; the refashioning of social relations of class by the linking of Indian economic regions to wider capitalist systems; and the impact of the interplay between national, communal and regional levels of politics on the process of decolonization. Various works on these themes have differed in their relative emphasis on the affinities or contradictions of class and caste, religion and language, nation and region, community and gender, economics and politics, and so on. The ‘subaltern studies’ group, for instance, began with a political conception of class before going on to stress culture and consciousness over economics and politics as explanatory variables. The twenty-first century has seen valuable contributions in at least three areas of South Asian historiography – the formation of regional and religious identities going beyond the dead-end debate between secular statist and subaltern communitarian perspectives; the place of South Asian economy and culture within larger inter-regional and global arenas of interaction; and the articulation and global circulation of economic and political ideas emanating from South Asia. The more insightful contributions of not only schools of historiography but individual scholars need to be weighed and placed into a broader and more meaningful framework for the study of modern South Asian history.

A meaningful framework for conceiving the history of modern South Asia on a subcontinental scale may be provided by the twin dialectics of centralism and regionalism and of nationalism and communitarianism, so long as there is a keen awareness of the historically shifting definitions of

and relationships between centre, region, nation and community. This is of the essence if we are to establish the contours of both the idea and the structure of India or South Asia on the basis of an analysis of the relationship of its constituent parts to the whole. Once this is done it becomes possible at the central and regional levels, and within the arenas of nation and community, to probe the relations of power along lines of class and gender. As the different parts and the whole of South Asia became more organically linked to a wider capitalist world from the early nineteenth century, critical alterations took place in social relations within the sub-continent. These occurred not only along the axis of class but were also refracted through myriad social and cultural relationships, including those of caste and community as well as gender and generation. These social and cultural relationships were not only inheritances from the past but were in the process of constant renegotiation and reformulation during the colonial era. Religious strife in contemporary India, for example, has little to do with any supposed ancient religious divide between Hindu and Muslim and cannot be explained without accounting for the invention of communally defined political categories in the early twentieth century and the historically dynamic dialectic between communitarian and provincial as well as religious and linguistic identities. The history of South Asian nationalisms has unfolded within larger transnational contexts. The interplay of nationalism and universalism is a subject that has received nuanced treatment in recent historical studies. Both the temporal thresholds and spatial boundaries of the sub-continent are in the process of being re-evaluated by historians.

How does our own location in what has been termed the post-modern era shape our perspectives on modern history? Despite our firm rejection of an uncritical celebration of the 'fragment' inherent in a particular brand of post-modernism, we believe it is important to recognize that the march of history has left some of the certitudes of high modernism by the wayside. A modern history of modern South Asia would have confidently tracked the unilinear emergence of the nation-state in the political domain, the teleological path of capitalist (or socialist) development in the economic sphere and the slow but sure triumph of modernity over anachronistic, traditional social bonds and values. The cracking and crumbling of the modern nation-state system, the disintegration of the socialist alternative and the disillusionment with the false promises of capitalism, and the resurgence of redefined social identities thought to have been obliterated by the steam-roller of modernization have all rendered interpretations of the modern era in South Asian and world history much more complex. Along with a greater sensitivity to difference and distinctiveness, the spotlight had been shifting in the late twentieth century towards the fragmentary parts rather than the monolithic whole of modern social, economic and political structures. Yet the intellectual breakaway from modernist dogma may have swung a little too far towards the fissures and away from the fusions which

formed an equally important aspect of the historical process. The ties of the subcontinent to the Indian Ocean inter-regional arena and the global context are being freshly recognized as historically significant. A recourse to South Asian history, where the dialectic between union and partition, centripetal and centrifugal tendencies, territorial nationalism and extra-territorial universalism, the secular and the religious are so dramatically played out, may well enable a much-needed decentred balance in our current disoriented scholarly predicament.